Activity 9 — Drawing the Line — Escalation and Abuse at a Service Counter

Topic	9 — Understanding When to Escalate
Mapping	LO2 · Distinguish anger from abuse, apply the three-strike rule, escalate correctly and document.
Format	Role Play + Decision Exercise
Duration	15 minutes
Roles	Trios. A = Service Officer, B = Mr Teo (trainer may play this role), C = supervisor/observer.

The Scenario

You are a service officer at a telco flagship store on Orchard Road. Mr Douglas Teo is disputing a S$680 roaming bill from a trip to Australia. He says he was never told data roaming was not included. The account notes show a confirmation SMS was sent and opened. The charge is valid under the contract.

The interaction escalates over 8 minutes:
0:00 He raises his voice: 'This is daylight robbery.'
2:00 'Are you stupid? Can you even read English?'
4:00 He calls you an offensive name related to your race.
5:30 'I'm going to CASE, and I'll have your job. What's your full name and NRIC?'
7:00 He steps behind the counter line, moves within arm's reach, and points a finger in your face.

Other customers are present. Your supervisor is on the shop floor. There is a duress button under the counter and CCTV covering the area.

What You Will Produce

A completed escalation decision log and an incident report for the abusive interaction.

Materials: Escalation trigger checklist · Incident report template · Three-strike rule card.

Discussion Questions

1. Go through the timeline. At each timestamp, classify the behaviour as ANGRY or ABUSIVE. Where exactly is the line?

2. Which timestamp is the point of no return — where continuing to serve is the wrong decision? Justify it.

3. Apply the three-strike rule to this timeline. What are your two warnings, word for word?

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4. Is this functional escalation or hierarchical escalation? Would your answer change if the dispute were technical rather than behavioural?

5. He demands your full name and NRIC. What are you obliged to give, and what are you not?

6. At 7:00 he is within arm's reach and pointing at your face. What do you do in the next 5 seconds, in order?

7. What must go into the incident report, and why does the exact wording he used need to be recorded verbatim?

Step-by-Step

1. Individually, take the escalation trigger checklist and classify each of the five timestamps as ANGRY or ABUSIVE. Do this before any discussion so you commit to a personal threshold first.

2. Compare in your trio. Where you disagree, argue it out. Most disagreement clusters around 2:00 ('are you stupid') — insulting your competence versus insulting you as a person.

3. As a group, mark the single timestamp you consider the point of no return. Write one sentence justifying it. Be prepared to defend it to the class.

4. Write your two warnings word for word on the three-strike card. Read them aloud to each other — if either sounds sarcastic or raised when spoken, rewrite it.

5. Run the role play from 0:00. B escalates on the timeline; A responds. The trainer may play B for this activity because the racial slur is difficult to deliver as a peer.

6. A issues warning one at the appropriate point, and warning two at 4:00 while simultaneously signalling the supervisor. A does NOT continue trying to resolve the bill after 4:00.

7. A hands over to C (supervisor) with a clean, brief handover in front of the customer: the issue, what has been offered, and the behaviour that triggered the escalation. A then physically withdraws.

8. Run the 7:00 physical-proximity moment separately as a freeze-frame exercise. A demonstrates the five-second sequence: step back, hands visible, verbal boundary, signal, duress button.

9. A completes the incident report template: date, time, location, verbatim words, witnesses, CCTV reference, actions taken, notifications made. Verbatim means verbatim — do not sanitise it.

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10. As a group, add the POHA and TAFEP references to the report: harassment at work is a criminal matter, reportable to TAFEP or the police, and the employer has a legal duty to provide a safe workplace.

11. Close with the wellbeing step most teams skip: what does the officer need AFTER this interaction — a break, a debrief with the supervisor, and a follow-up the next day.

Debrief — What a Strong Answer Looks Like

- The line: 0:00 and 2:00 are anger directed at the situation and then at your competence — unpleasant but serviceable. 4:00 is the crossing point: a racial slur is abuse of the PERSON and is a criminal matter under POHA, not a service problem.
- Point of no return is 4:00, not 7:00. Most learners wait for the physical proximity. Waiting until you feel physically unsafe means you served through the abuse — the threshold is the slur, and it is not negotiable or 'part of the job'.
- Warnings must be calm, specific and behavioural: 'Mr Teo, I want to help you with this bill, but I cannot continue if you speak to me that way.' Second: 'If that continues I will need to hand this to my supervisor and end our conversation.' Never sarcastic, never raised.
- This is HIERARCHICAL escalation — it needs authority, not expertise. A technical roaming dispute would be FUNCTIONAL escalation to a billing specialist. Same customer, same bill, entirely different escalation path.
- You give your first name or staff ID — that is standard and reasonable. You never give your NRIC or personal details. Deflect: 'my name is X and my staff ID is Y, and my supervisor will give you the complaint reference.'
- At 7:00, in order: step back to restore distance, keep hands visible and open, do not turn your back, say clearly 'please step back behind the counter', signal or press for the supervisor, and press the duress button if he does not comply. Do not attempt to win the exchange.
- The report needs date, time, location, the exact words used verbatim, witnesses present, CCTV reference, actions taken and who was notified. Verbatim matters because POHA and any police report turn on what was actually said — paraphrase destroys the evidence.

Check Your Work

You identified 4:00 as the escalation threshold, delivered two calm behavioural warnings, handed over without continuing to serve, and produced an incident report containing the verbatim wording and a CCTV reference.

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